

AIRCRAFT CARRIERS

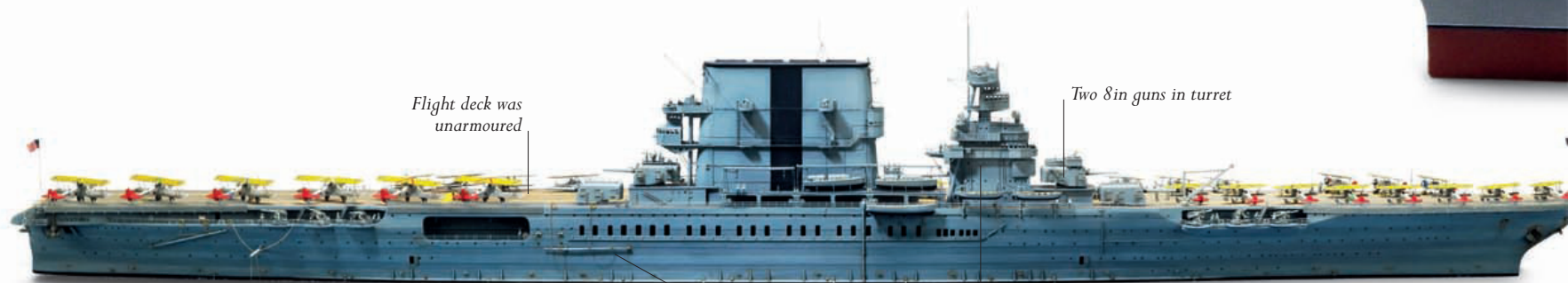
The earliest aircraft-carrying ships actually functioned as floating seaplane bases. Although experimentation had taken place earlier, it was not until after World War I that true aircraft carriers, capable of launching aircraft and recovering them, entered service. By 1939, significant advances had been made, and the British Royal Navy had a dozen such carriers in operation or under construction. The Imperial Japanese Navy had a similar number, and the US Navy had eight. It was the US Navy that subsequently embraced the type most wholeheartedly, constructing huge numbers of "fleet" carriers, and lighter, less-capable "escort" carriers during the course of World War II. Many such escort carriers were also constructed in the US for the British Royal Navy.



▲ HMS FURIOUS

Commissioned	1917	Origin	UK
Displacement	22,890 tons		
Length	239.7m (786½ft)		
Top speed	30 knots		

Ordered as a light battlecruiser, *Furious* was completed as a makeshift aircraft carrier with a short flying-off deck forward. It was later completely reconstructed from the main deck upwards, and equipped to operate 36 aircraft. It served with distinction, almost unscathed, until September 1944.



▲ USS SARATOGA

Commissioned	1927	Origin	US
Displacement	43,055 tons		
Length	270.7m (888ft)		
Top speed	33 knots		

Ordered as part of a group of six battlecruisers at the end of World War I, *Saratoga* and sister-ship *Lexington* were selected for completion as carriers. It became the US Navy's first effective carrier, and survived World War II, winning seven battle stars.

Flight deck was unarmoured

Hangar deck

Two 8in guns in turret

Command bridge and flight operations control centre

"Island" contained bridge and flight control

Two levels of hangar deck

Two 4¾in anti-aircraft guns



▲ AKAGI

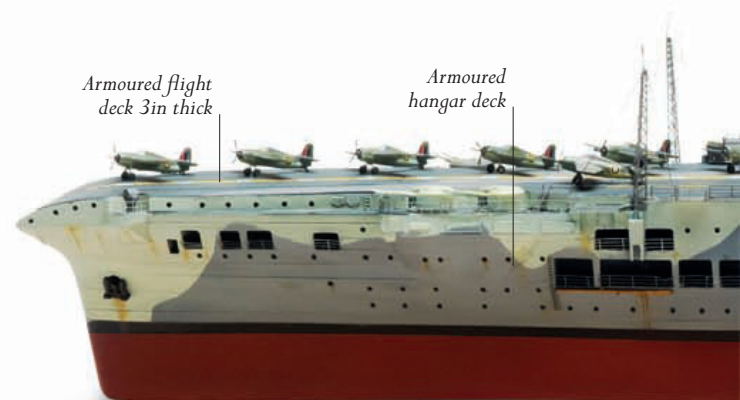
Commissioned	1927	Origin	Japan
Displacement	42,750 tons		
Length	260.7m (855½ft)		
Top speed	31 knots		

Akagi was completed as a carrier with a three-level flight deck, which allowed aircraft to take off from hangar-deck levels and land on the (truncated) upper deck. The boiler flues were on the starboard side, and an island was not fitted until *Akagi* was comprehensively rebuilt along more orthodox lines between 1935-38.

Hull had bulges to improve stability and give protection against torpedoes

Armoured flight deck 3in thick

Armoured hangar deck



▼ HMS ARK ROYAL

Commissioned	1938	Origin	UK
Displacement	27,720 tons		
Length	243.8m (800ft)		
Top speed	31 knots		

The British Royal Navy's first large purpose-built aircraft carrier, *Ark Royal* introduced many design elements – including steam catapults – that were used in later types. Though well protected, it succumbed to a torpedo in the Mediterranean in 1941, having ferried much-needed aircraft to Malta.

Two 4.5in high-angle quick-firing guns

Flight operations control platform

Four 2-pounder "pom-pom" anti-aircraft guns

Upper hangar deck

